

cura personalis

In the early months of 2022, I was nominated by my Georgetown students to become an honorary member of the university's chapter of the Jesuit honor society, Alpha Sigma Nu, and invited to give the keynote at a ceremony in which I, another faculty member, and seventy-four students would be inducted and celebrated. I include the speech here in its entirety—it's a fitting coda to the book. That the speech made some Georgetown administrators and faculty intensely uncomfortable—for both its (very mild!) profanity and its message—and made my students in attendance extremely happy tells me I'm still moving in the right direction. It's perhaps a distillation of the central argument of this book and my entire oeuvre over the last decade, crafted into a loving message to students—because who better to receive it than those who taught me what it means to be unwell and create care? If you're able to read nothing else in this book, read this. The message is for you, too.

Cura Personalis in Pandemic Times

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Thank you to the students who invited me to speak today and who nominated me to be an honorary member of Alpha Sigma Nu. It is deeply meaningful to me to be recognized by students because that is who I feel I serve first and foremost in my work as a teacher, scholar, and artist. My commitments are to students, above all, above any institution or peers, so my remarks today will be directed to you, the students here.

We are here today to celebrate all of you for your excellence. I admit I did not know much about Alpha Sigma Nu before this invitation—I'm fairly new to Georgetown, joining as the Scholar/Artist/Activist in Residence in Disability Studies in January 2020 and then staying on as a part-time lecturer since—so I took some time to do a little research. On Georgetown's chapter's website: "The purpose of the Society shall be to honor students of Jesuit institutions of higher education who distinguish themselves in scholarship, loyalty and service. . . . Of the competitive and highly accomplished pool of ambitious Georgetown students, only about 1.2% are ultimately invited to join the Georgetown chapter of Alpha Sigma Nu."

This is prestigious. You are being recognized for your achievements in multiple realms. Not just your academics but also your character, as expressed in the values of loyalty and service. You are the top 1 percent among students here, exemplars for how much you've done and how much you've given. There is real calculable achievement here. And real hard work and sacrifice. I am sure you have made an enormous impact on the lives around you through your dedication to these values. Y'all are the shit.

I believe y'all are the shit, and I am not here to take that away from you. But I *am* here to tell you that you are more than what you achieve. You are more than even what Georgetown celebrates in you. Excellence is not and should not be the measure of your personhood.

We talk a lot about care here at Georgetown. *Cura personalis*, students have told me, means "care of the whole person." I've been fascinated by that part of Georgetown's mission since I joined its contingent faculty. It's the first time

I've seen care as part of a university's central commitments. My work is in mental health, in thinking about care (and need) in terms of structures, in terms of the collective, in terms of the contexts of uncaring we all differentially encounter. I want to know what kinds of care we need and how to build it, together. I want to teach students, you, that you deserve the care you need, that you do not have to make yourself smaller, make your needs nonexistent, make your pain invisible, in order to be seen as excellent and therefore worthy. You do not have to be excellent to deserve care. This is what I teach in my classes here at Georgetown, in my talks and workshops at universities across the country, in my writing and curatorial work. The simplest of lessons but for some reason one of the hardest to learn.

I have found that my students at Georgetown have welcomed this lesson enthusiastically, sometimes with a kind of desperation, though, that makes my heart ache—and tells me they are learning something else in many places outside my classroom.

What does care look like at Georgetown?

When I came here at the beginning of 2020, that was one of my questions, because, as I said, I had never encountered an institution whose mission centralized care. But before I could even begin to investigate that, I knew it was important to first check in with the real experts here at Georgetown: the students. A university can say it cares all it wants, but if students say they don't feel cared for, this thing called caring is not actually happening. Or at least, it's not happening very effectively.

I've asked every student I've encountered at Georgetown over the last two years if they feel that Georgetown cares about them. Parents and administrators here today will probably not like hearing this, but the answer I've gotten is a definitive, reverberating "no." Individual faculty may show care, both affectively and structurally, in their courses. Peers show care. Students feel cared for intermittently, at the micro and macro levels, by individual people, maybe even departments and programs, maybe even particular university policies and initiatives. But the feeling is not sustained across Georgetown, nor is it sustained across their years here in any holistic sense. There is a major disconnect happening, because Georgetown is not lying when it says it cares and wants to build care for students. I've gotten email after email during the pandemic about ways the university cares, policies and structures being created to try to support students *and* faculty and staff, and these feel for the most part sincere, often involving real labor and effort.

In fact, the pandemic has ushered all of us into an unprecedented crisis of care. There are new needs, overwhelming in scope and scale, emerging con-

stantly, necessitating the constant creation of structures of care, both collective and individual. We have to think about taking care of ourselves and each other in new, heightened ways, and the stakes have never felt higher. They are literally life and death.

But what I've learned in my mental health work over the last decade is that it has always been a matter of life and death for so many of us. We just might not have realized it. I won't quote you statistics about suicidal ideation among students, queer and trans folks, BIPOC peoples, but they are scary. We all have always needed care, for all the spectacularly awful ways we experience unwellness and suffering. We have always needed differential care—meaning, care that takes into account the different and very specific ways we experience unwellness in relation to the structures we encounter.

We just pretend we don't. Because we don't think we are supposed to need and receive care.

We are now approaching year three of the pandemic. Over the course of the last two years, I've watched policies come and go, structures of support wax and wane, access expanded and collapsed across universities all over the country. Perhaps there have been moments in which some students felt holistically cared for, but so many students have continued to tell me throughout the pandemic that they do not feel cared for. This past week, I visited a course here as a guest speaker, and I asked students whether they feel Georgetown cares about them, and they actually laughed. That is probably very hard for those in charge of caring to hear. But hear they must—otherwise they will keep missing the mark and failing the only litmus test that really matters.

I'm not here today to tell Georgetown or any university how to do better. (Don't worry—I do that a lot on other days, and sometimes even get paid for it.) I'm here to tell you, students, that you deserve the care you have not been getting. I'm here to tell you that you are allowed to ask for it, to demand it. You deserve to feel cared for as whole people, and only *you* get to say what *cura personalis* looks like and if it has been achieved. I will hazard an attempt, though, to outline what I think are its main elements, based on what I've heard from students here and across the country, and based on my own scholarly work in disability studies and mental health.

I think that *cura personalis* means you deserve care, at all times, not because you are excellent, not because of your achievements, but because you are human. That means you are allowed to hurt. Allowed to say life is hard, too hard. Allowed to need things, to ask for what we sometimes call accommodations, without shame. Allowed to let go of what we in disability justice call “the myth of independence,” or the idea that we all can and should func-

tion independently, that it is *moral* to be independent, immoral to be dependent. That something is wrong with you if you can't get your shit together and do all the things you think you're supposed to do. You are allowed to *not* have your shit together.

To me, *cura personalis* means you are allowed to fail. Not fail as in fall through the cracks and be abandoned. Fail as in not meet the ableist standards of so-called excellence and still feel like a good, deserving, whole person. You do not have to be perfect. You will not be abandoned, no matter what.

You have been told, probably every step of the way through all the institutions you've grown up in, that you must be productive and extraordinarily so in order to deserve good things in this life. You will continue to be told this in all the institutions you move through once you leave here. I want you to resist this message. I want you to know that this is what ableism looks and feels like—a strangling of personhood down to normative perfection that leaves all of us dying in its wake. Some of us more quickly or intensely than others, but none of us are left unmarked. Ableism tells us there is an ideal person, body, mind that we have to aspire towards, and any deviation from that renders us less-than, maybe even worthless. Ableism tells us to need is to be weak, to be weak is to be a failure, to fail is to be undeserving. I want you to know it is possible to reject this system of valuation and find different ways to value yourself and others, different ways to be in the world. I want you to know it is possible to build care with others, interdependently, leaning into our needs and limits to do the collective work of care we all deserve. Think of all the forms of mutual aid that have sprung up during the pandemic, to distribute masks and diapers and food and vaccines to those without. We can have that all the time, and not just for our basic needs but also for our mental health needs, our access needs, our social needs, our needs for stability and support and the knowledge that we are not alone and we will not be left behind.

We all deserve belonging, safety, happiness, nourishment, joy, meaning, comfort, love, rest—whether or not we achieve or produce another goddamn thing for the rest of our lives.

Thank you.

Wait—I can't let you go without one last set of activities!

This is a book of letters you've been reading. Now it's your turn to write a few.

Start with one to yourself, past or present or future. Now that you've read this book, what do you want to remind yourself or teach yourself in this mo-